

SUNDAY

FOCUS ON: Daniel in Babylon

READ TOGETHER: Daniel 1

ANCHORED BY FAITHFULNESS

But Daniel purposed in his heart that he
would not defile himself... (Daniel 1:8)

FOR FAMILY WORSHIP: Pages 12-14

FURTHER STUDY FOR PARENTS: Pages 15-17

DANIEL'S QUIET STRENGTH

Imagine Daniel standing before a giant palace. The doors opened wide. The walls were bright. The halls were long. Servants hurried by. Music filled the air. The king's food smelled sweet and rich. Everything seemed to shout, "Babylon is big! Babylon is strong! This is your new life!"

But Daniel did not choose this place. He did not choose this school. He did not choose this king. He did not even choose his new name. His home was far away. His world felt shaken. In a **VUCA WORLD**, life can feel wild, unsure, confusing, and hard to understand. Daniel had to choose how to live.

Babylon wanted Daniel to learn its language. Babylon wanted Daniel to eat its food. Babylon wanted Daniel to act like everyone else. But Daniel knew something deep inside: "I belong to God."

Then came the king's food. Picture shiny plates. Sweet drinks. Fancy meals. Maybe other boys

stared at those things and smiled. It looked like a prize. It looked like success. It may have looked harmless.

But Daniel saw more than food. He saw a choice. Would he let Babylon shape his heart? Or would he remember God first?

The Bible says, "Daniel purposed in his heart..." (Daniel 1:8). That means Daniel decided inside, where only God could see.

He did not yell. He did not act proud. He did not fight the workers. Daniel was brave, but his bravery was calm. He asked kindly for another way.

That is the kind of heart God can grow in us. A heart that says yes to God before pressure comes. A heart that knows, "I am God's child."

Today, screens, games, videos, likes, and trends can try to shape our hearts too. Daniel reminds us that brave choices often start quietly. Before anyone sees us, God sees our hearts. Like a little light in the dark, one quiet choice can shine too. When we choose God in secret, our life begins to shine in public.

FAMILY PRAYER

Kneel together with open hands and pray: **"Lord, give our family humble hearts that choose You first, even when pressure feels strong. In Jesus' name, amen."**

Daniel's world became scary and confusing:

God helped him know what to do:

VOLATILE: Home destroyed, taken away.

VENTURE: God helps us be brave with our choices.

UNCERTAIN: New language, culture, empire.

UNVEIL: God shows what is true in His word.

COMPLEX: Pressure from every side.

COMPASS: God shows the right way, by trusting Him.

AMBIGUOUS: Stay faithful, live with others.

ASSURANCE: God says, "You are Mine; I'll protect you."

Even in a **VUCA WORLD**, a surrendered heart chooses God's way—brave, kind, wise, and faithful, not fearful or reactive.

1 Read Daniel 1:8 together

2 Underline the word "**purposed**"

3 Ask yourself:

- Is my faithfulness public or private?
- Which digital choices change when watched?

We do this because God's love gives our hearts a safe home. When we know we belong to Him, we want to choose what makes Him smile. We can lean on Him and feel His love daily. **I belong to God, so His love helps me choose well, even when I am alone.**

FAMILY ACTIVITY: The Secret Heart Check

Find a sticky note and draw a small heart. Place it near your main device. For 24 hours, before opening it, stop and pray: "Jesus, lead my heart." Do not post for likes. Do not watch what makes you forget you belong to God. **At bedtime, let's ask each other: Who ruled my heart today?**



FURTHER STUDY
FOR PARENTS:

ANCHORED BY FAITHFULNESS

Today's Principle:
A Surrendered Heart

Today's promise for your home is simple and hopeful:
Your family can learn to choose God before pressure comes.

Screen rules are not just limits; they are little training paths for the heart. As children remember, “I belong to God,” wise choices can grow quietly, lovingly, and bravely—even when no one is watching inside your home every day.

V VENTURE BEYOND FEAR IN A VOLATILE WORLD

Daniel lived in a **VUCA WORLD**: volatile, because Jerusalem was destroyed and his life changed fast; uncertain, because he faced a new language, culture, and empire; complex, because political and religious pressure surrounded him; and ambiguous, because he had to stay faithful without hiding from the world or becoming like Babylon.

This matters for parents because our children also live in a **VUCA WORLD**. Screens, trends, voices, and pressures can try to shape what they love, believe, and choose. Daniel teaches us that the first battle is not outside the home. It is inside the heart.

Daniel 1:8 says he “purposed in his heart” not to defile himself. His courage began in the unseen. Before the public test, his heart was surrendered to God.

This is keystone knowledge for our children: when the heart belongs to God, choices grow stronger.

WHERE IS YOUR FAITHFULNESS DECIDED TODAY: IN PUBLIC, OR IN SECRET?

U UNVEIL DEEPER TRUTH IN UNCERTAIN TIMES

Read Daniel 1:8 slowly. Pause at “purposed.” Daniel did not wait for the loud moment. He chose God before pressure knocked at the door.

“Before the pressure comes” means today—before your child asks, before friends compare, before guilt whispers, before tiredness reaches for the phone, and before the screen becomes the easy answer.

ASK GOD, RIGHT NOW, TO HELP YOU SEE YOUR OWN HEART: What is guiding my choices? What do I do only when others see? Today’s quiet decisions may become tomorrow’s lessons for my child.

C COMPASS THAT REMAINS STEADY THROUGH COMPLEXITY

Daniel’s steady compass was not fear. It was reverence for the Lord. To fear God does not mean running away from Him. It means living awake to who He is and who we are before Him. God is the center, not me. He sees farther than I do. He loves better than I understand.

A surrendered heart learns this truth: not everything I want is good for me. Freedom needs limits. Obedience is not shame. It is trust. In your home, this matters because, as a parent, you are not only making screen rules. You are helping lead your child’s heart toward God.

Educational principles from Ellen White remind us that true education begins with love and relationship. Ellen White wrote, **“Love, the basis of creation and of redemption, is the basis of true education”** (Education, p. 16). This helps us understand that children are not shaped best by cold rules, fear, or constant checking. They are shaped through loving relationships, patient guidance, and a living connection with God.

Daniel did not say no because someone was watching him. He said no because he already knew he belonged to God. That is the kind of heart we want to help form in our children.

Screens often whisper, “Look at this. Compare yourself. Prove yourself. Post now.” But a surrendered heart learns to pause and ask, “Will this bring me closer to the person God is helping me become? Am I seeking attention, or living with purpose? Does this honor God and others?”

This is the meaning of “First I belong, then I choose.” When a child knows, “I am God’s beloved child,” they can begin to make choices that match that identity.

Your goal is not simply to control your child’s screen use from the outside, but to help your child grow an inner compass fixed on Jesus.

PUBLIC FAITHFULNESS IS BORN FROM PRIVATE SURRENDER.

A ASSURANCE THAT STANDS FIRM AMID AMBIGUITY

Today’s practice is called **THE INVISIBLE ACT**. It is not a test to prove your spirituality. It is a small way to practice surrender when no one is watching.

For the next 24 hours, let this practice begin with you, not your child. Before opening your main device, pause and ask Jesus to lead your heart. Choose not to post for approval, not to watch or read what weakens your identity in God, and not to use screens to escape His quiet invitation. Your children learn from the way you choose when no one is watching.

TONIGHT, ASK YOURSELF: WHO RULED MY HEART TODAY WHEN NO ONE WAS WATCHING?



ANCHORED BY FAITHFULNESS

Babylon could change Daniel’s name, but not his heart. Today, anchor your children in this truth: when the heart belongs to God, identity stays strong, even in a **VUCA WORLD**.